
RL.7.2

Theme & Objective Summary

Grade 7 ELA • Multiple-Choice Task Cards

5 questions with the teacher **6 questions** independent

Answer key follows every task card



STANDARD

Determine a theme of a text and analyze its development over the course of the text; provide an objective summary of the text.

What students do

Students establish the theme of a literary text and examine its progression throughout the text. Using the theme and key details, students summarize the text, being sure to omit any personal opinions or bias.

GLOSSARY

theme — the subject or underlying meaning that a literary text directly or indirectly explains, develops, and/or explores

analyze — to critically examine the components of a subject to understand its meaning and/or nature as a whole

objective summary — a brief account of a text's central points, themes, or ideas that is free of bias, prejudice, and personal opinion and does not add outside information

text — anything students can read, write, view, listen to, or explore — books, photographs, films, articles, music, art, and more

theme

DEFINITION

The subject or underlying meaning a literary text explains, develops, or explores — stated as a full sentence.

EXAMPLE

“Real progress is measured by growth, not by placing.” (The Last Lap)

analyze

DEFINITION

To critically examine the parts of something in order to understand its meaning as a whole.

EXAMPLE

Tracking how a theme shifts from the first page of a story to the last.

objective summary

DEFINITION

A brief account of a text's central ideas — free of bias, opinion, and outside information.

EXAMPLE

“Diego restores his grandfather’s boat over one winter.” Not: “The boat story is beautiful.”

text

DEFINITION

Anything students can read, write, view, listen to, or explore.

EXAMPLE

A short story, a photograph, a film clip, an article, or a song.

development

DEFINITION

How an idea grows, deepens, or changes across the beginning, middle, and end of a text.

EXAMPLE

Nasir moves from boasting, to relying on Tessa, to admitting it aloud.

bias

DEFINITION

A personal opinion or preference that favors one side of something.

EXAMPLE

“Ruth was a selfish daughter” is bias; “Ruth resented the night shifts” is evidence.

Highlight & Annotate

- Determine the theme of the text.
- Highlight every place in the text where the theme appears.
- Annotate each highlighted portion: how does the theme progress or change from its last appearance?
- Review your annotations and share your findings with a partner.



SWBST Objective Summary

The teacher models the protocol; students then write objective summaries.

Somebody

the main character or narrator

Wanted

their motive

But

the major conflict and the theme

So

how they addressed the conflict and theme

Then

how the conflict was resolved

How to Use These Task Cards

Directions

1

Read the passage

Read the passage on the left of the card aloud (guided) or silently (independent).

2

Answer both questions

Each card holds two multiple-choice questions. Choose the best answer, A–D.

3

Check the key

The answer key slide follows each card, with the reasoning for every answer.

4

Talk it through

Point to the words in the passage that prove your answer before moving on.

Large print • one passage per card • all questions multiple choice

TOPIC

A word or phrase: what the text is about.

courage · family · friendship · growing up

THEME

A full sentence: what the text says about that topic.

"Real courage often looks quiet, and it usually costs something."

Tracing a theme's development

BEGINNING

Where does the idea first appear?

MIDDLE

What complicates or challenges it?

TURN

What moment changes the character's view?

END

What does the text finally say about it?

An objective summary reports these four moves — and nothing you think about them.

WITH THE TEACHER

Guided Practice

5 multiple-choice questions across 3 task cards. Read together, think aloud, and prove each answer with evidence from the passage.





PASSAGE

The Last Lap

Maya had trained all season for the mile, and for three laps she held second place. On the final turn her legs went heavy, and two runners slipped past her. She finished fifth. Afterward she sat on the infield grass, certain the season had been wasted. Her coach knelt beside her and pulled out a worn notebook. In September, Maya had run the mile in seven minutes and two seconds. Today the clock read six minutes and eleven seconds. "The place doesn't tell your story," the coach said. "This does." Maya looked at the two numbers for a long moment. The next Monday, she was the first runner on the track.

QUESTION 1

Which statement best expresses the theme of "The Last Lap"?

- A. Runners who train hardest always finish first.
- B. Real progress is measured by growth, not by placing.
- C. Coaches should keep detailed records of every athlete.
- D. Losing a race means the season has been wasted.

QUESTION 2

How does the theme develop over the course of the passage?

- A. It stays the same because Maya never changes her mind.
- B. It shifts from confidence to regret at the finish line.
- C. It moves from Maya judging herself by her place to judging herself by her progress.
- D. It moves from teamwork to competition between runners.

Passage: The Last Lap

QUESTION 1

Which statement best expresses the theme of "The Last Lap"?

B

Real progress is measured by growth, not by placing.

Why: The coach's notebook shifts Maya from her finish (fifth) to her improvement (51 seconds faster), and she returns to practice — growth, not placement, is what matters.

QUESTION 2

How does the theme develop over the course of the passage?

C

It moves from Maya judging herself by her place to judging herself by her progress.

Why: Maya begins certain the season was "wasted," the coach introduces the two times, and the ending — first on the track Monday — shows her new measure of success.



PASSAGE

Grandfather's Boat

The boat had sat behind the shed for eleven years, its blue paint curling like old bark. Diego wanted to sell it for scrap. His grandmother handed him a can of varnish instead. "Your grandfather sanded it every spring," she said, "and he never once finished in a single day." Diego worked two hours each Saturday through the winter. Some weeks the hull looked worse than when he started. By April the wood had turned honey-colored, and neighbors stopped at the fence to look. When Diego finally rowed it onto the bay, he understood that his grandfather had not been repairing a boat. He had been keeping a promise, one small season at a time.

QUESTION 3

Which theme is developed in "Grandfather's Boat"?

- A. Old objects are usually not worth saving.
- B. Honoring the people we love takes patient, repeated effort.
- C. Neighbors should be consulted before starting a project.
- D. Selling what we inherit is a practical choice.

QUESTION 4

Which detail best shows the theme deepening rather than simply repeating?

- A. The paint on the hull was curling like old bark.
- B. Diego first wanted to sell the boat for scrap.
- C. Neighbors stopped at the fence to look at the wood.
- D. Diego realizes his grandfather was keeping a promise, not repairing a boat.

Passage: Grandfather's Boat

QUESTION 3

Which theme is developed in "Grandfather's Boat"?

B

Honoring the people we love takes patient, repeated effort.

Why: Diego works two hours every Saturday for months and finally sees the boat as "a promise" his grandfather kept "one small season at a time."

QUESTION 4

Which detail best shows the theme deepening rather than simply repeating?

D

Diego realizes his grandfather was keeping a promise, not repairing a boat.

Why: The final line moves the idea beyond the physical work: Diego reinterprets the whole task as devotion, which is a development of the theme, not a repetition.



PASSAGE

The Empty Lot

For years the lot on Ash Street held broken glass and a rusted swing frame. Mrs. Okoye asked the city for a garden and was told there was no money. So she brought a shovel and worked alone. The first week, no one joined her. The second week, two boys carried away tires. By June, eleven families had claimed beds of tomatoes, mint, and peppers, and someone had painted the fence. A reporter asked Mrs. Okoye how she had convinced the block to help. She laughed. "I never convinced anyone," she said. "I just kept showing up where they could see me."

QUESTION 5

Which sentence is the most objective summary of "The Empty Lot"?

- A. A wonderful woman single-handedly saved a sad, ugly neighborhood that had given up hope.
- B. After the city refused to fund a garden, Mrs. Okoye began clearing a vacant lot alone; over several months neighbors joined until eleven families were gardening there.
- C. The city was wrong to refuse Mrs. Okoye money for her garden project on Ash Street.
- D. Everyone should follow Mrs. Okoye's example and start a garden in their own neighborhood.

Passage: The Empty Lot

QUESTION 5

Which sentence is the most objective summary of "The Empty Lot"?

B

After the city refused to fund a garden, Mrs. Okoye began clearing a vacant lot alone; over several months neighbors joined until eleven families were gardening there.

Why: Only this choice reports the main events in order without praise, blame, opinion, or outside advice — the requirements of an objective summary.

ON YOUR OWN

Independent Practice

6 multiple-choice questions across 3 task cards. Read carefully, choose the best answer, then check the key that follows.





PASSAGE

The Practice Room

Every recital program listed Ivy Chen as first violin, exactly as her parents expected. She practiced four hours a day and won every audition she entered. But in the empty practice room she kept a second folder, filled with songs she had written herself — messy, unfinished, entirely hers. For two years she never played them for anyone. At the spring showcase, the scheduled soloist fell ill, and the director asked Ivy to fill six minutes. She could have played the concerto in her sleep. Instead she opened the second folder. Her hands shook through the first eight bars. Then, for the first time on a stage, the sound was her own.

QUESTION 6

Which statement best expresses the theme of "The Practice Room"?

- A. Musicians perform better when they are nervous.
- B. Talent matters more than practice in the end.
- C. Finding your own voice can matter more than meeting others' expectations.
- D. Soloists should always have a backup prepared.

QUESTION 7

Which detail most clearly signals the theme before the showcase?

- A. Her parents expected her name on every program.
- B. She kept a second folder of her own unfinished songs.
- C. She practiced four hours every day.
- D. The scheduled soloist fell ill.

Passage: The Practice Room

QUESTION 6

Which statement best expresses the theme of "The Practice Room"?

C

Finding your own voice can matter more than meeting others' expectations.

Why: Ivy could play the expected concerto perfectly, but she chooses her own compositions, and the closing line names the change: "the sound was her own."

QUESTION 7

Which detail most clearly signals the theme before the showcase?

B

She kept a second folder of her own unfinished songs.

Why: The hidden folder plants the private, authentic self early, so the stage choice later completes a development the reader has already been shown.



PASSAGE

Above the Treeline

Nasir had insisted on leading. He was the faster hiker, and he told Tessa so twice before the trail turned to ice. Above the treeline the wind erased their footprints, and the cairns he had been counting on disappeared under fresh snow. Tessa stopped, unzipped her pack, and pulled out the paper map and compass she had carried up without mentioning them. Nasir stared at the map, then at her. Together they took a bearing and picked their way down to the shelter of the pines. That night, warming his hands over the stove, Nasir admitted something he had never said on a trail: he had been glad not to be alone.

QUESTION 8

Which theme is developed in "Above the Treeline"?

- A. Hikers should never travel above the treeline in winter.
- B. Pride can give way to trust when people depend on each other.
- C. Paper maps are more reliable than modern technology.
- D. The strongest member of a group should always lead.

QUESTION 9

How does the author develop the theme across the passage?

- A. By describing the weather in increasing detail.
- B. By comparing Nasir's speed to Tessa's speed with numbers.
- C. By moving Nasir from boasting, to relying on Tessa, to admitting it aloud.
- D. By keeping Nasir's opinion of himself unchanged from start to finish.

Passage: Above the Treeline

QUESTION 8

Which theme is developed in "Above the Treeline"?

B

Pride can give way to trust when people depend on each other.

Why: Nasir opens by asserting he is faster, the lost cairns strip that advantage, and he ends by admitting he was glad not to be alone.

QUESTION 9

How does the author develop the theme across the passage?

C

By moving Nasir from boasting, to relying on Tessa, to admitting it aloud.

Why: The theme advances through Nasir's changing position: claim, silent reliance on Tessa's map, then spoken admission at the stove.



PASSAGE

Night Shift

Ruth's mother baked from eleven at night until six in the morning, and Ruth resented it. Her mother slept through her games. Her mother smelled like flour at parent conferences. One December morning Ruth woke early and walked to the bakery to complain. Through the window she saw her mother sliding trays into the oven while three men from the shelter down the block sat at the counter with coffee, warm and unhurried. Her mother waved them off when they reached for their wallets. Ruth stood in the cold a long time. She went home, set her alarm for four, and said nothing. On Saturday, she showed up to help.

QUESTION 10

Which statement best expresses the theme of "Night Shift"?

- A. Bakeries are difficult businesses to run profitably.
- B. Children should be told exactly why their parents work.
- C. Understanding someone's sacrifice can change resentment into respect.
- D. Waking up early is the key to a successful life.

QUESTION 11

Which is the best objective summary of "Night Shift"?

- A. Ruth resents her mother's night baking until she sees her feeding men from a shelter for free; Ruth then begins helping.
- B. Ruth's mother is the most generous person in the neighborhood.
- C. Ruth was a selfish daughter who finally stopped complaining.
- D. Ruth's mother should have explained her charity work sooner.

Passage: Night Shift

QUESTION 10

Which statement best expresses the theme of "Night Shift"?

C

Understanding someone's sacrifice can change resentment into respect.

Why: Ruth goes to complain, sees her mother quietly feeding men from the shelter for free, and responds by setting her alarm to help — resentment becomes respect.

QUESTION 11

Which is the best objective summary of "Night Shift"?

A

Ruth resents her mother's night baking until she sees her feeding men from a shelter for free; Ruth then begins helping.

Why: It states the central events and the change in Ruth without judging characters or adding opinions or advice.

Before you leave

- Name the theme of one passage from today in a single sentence.
- Give two moments from that passage that show the theme developing.
- Write a three-sentence objective summary — no opinions, no outside information.

Check yourself

- ☐ My theme is a statement about life, not a one-word topic.
- ☐ I traced the theme across the beginning, middle, and end.
- ☐ My summary keeps only central ideas and key details.
- ☐ My summary contains no opinions, praise, blame, or outside facts.